

CORE FORMULA

Reflect first -> mode check -> permissioned suggestion -> fit check. -> "That sounds [hard part]. Do you want me to listen, help think it through, or suggest options?" -> "I have one thought, but I do not want to steamroll you. Useful, or not yet?" -> Operating rhythm: notice -> small move -> pause -> calibrate -> follow or release.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Reflect once, then ask: "Do you want ideas, or do you want me to just hear you out for a minute?"

BEST FOR

- Someone venting who needs to feel heard before anything else
- Friends or partners sharing a frustration, not asking for a fix
- Leadership and coaching, where advice should follow understanding
- Emotionally charged moments where a quick fix would feel dismissive
- Building trust, so people can talk to you without getting a lecture
- Making later advice land, because it fits the actual problem

PHRASE BANK

Quick restraint · Openers and quick texts

- "Before I try to solve it, that sounds really frustrating."
- "I'm going to resist advice-mode for a second."
- "Let me make sure I understand the hard part first."
- "I do not want to fix too fast and miss the point."
- "That sounds like a lot. Do you want a sounding board or suggestions?"
- "That sounds rough. Do you want advice or just a sympathetic witness?"
- "Before I give suggestions: what is the part that is most annoying?"
- "I have a thought if you want it, but no pressure."
- "Want me to help draft a reply, or are you just venting?"
- "I will not jump straight to fixing unless it is useful."

Mode check · Ask what they want

- "Do you want me to listen, help think it through, or suggest options?"
- "Are you wanting advice, or do you mostly need to vent this one out?"
- "Do you want comfort, clarity, or a plan?"
- "Would problem-solving help, or would that be annoying right now?"
- "Do you want my honest read, or just space to talk it through first?"

Reflect before advice · Name the hard part

- "The hard part sounds less like the task and more like feeling unsupported."
- "It sounds like you are not short on ideas; you are tired of carrying it."
- "That sounds frustrating because it was avoidable."
- "It sounds like the unfairness is the part that is sticking."
- "So this is less about what happened and more about what it meant."

Permissioned advice · Offer with consent

- "I have one thought, but only if you want suggestions."
- "Would it help if I offered a possible next step?"

- "Can I give you a practical option, or would that be too soon?"
- "My instinct is one thing, but I want to check you want advice first."
- "I can give you the short version of what I would try, if useful."
- "Okay, if we are in problem-solving mode, I would start small."
- "Given what you have said, I would not try to fix the whole thing today."
- "The move I would consider is one small change first."
- "The lowest-friction next step might be to name the pattern, not the incident."
- "The part I would protect first is your standing, not the deadline."

Social / friendship · Casual and low-key

- "That sounds awful. Do you want solutions or solidarity?"
- "I can be useful or just be outraged with you. Your call."
- "Do you want me in advice mode or friend mode?"
- "I can help solve it, but I also get if you just need to be annoyed for a minute."
- "That sounds miserable. I will not try to silver-line it."

Professional / leadership · Work, coaching, busy people

- "Before I suggest fixes, I want to understand the constraint."
- "Is this a moment for advice, or do you want me to help map the problem first?"
- "What outcome are you trying to protect here?"
- "Would a recommendation be useful now, or should we clarify the issue first?"
- "If you want options, I can give two possible paths."
- "Before I recommend, what constraint matters most?"
- "Do you want a quick read or a few options?"
- "I will hold advice until I know the outcome you are after."
- "What are you optimising for here?"
- "My concise suggestion, if useful, is to solve one part and revisit the rest."

Conflict-safe · Charged moments

- "I might be moving too quickly to solution mode. What do I need to understand first?"
- "I do not want to talk you out of the feeling. What part matters most?"
- "Before I respond, I want to separate what happened from what it meant."
- "I can see why advice might feel dismissive right now."
- "Let me slow down and hear the concern properly."

Shy or guarded · Low pressure

- "No need to solve it right now. I am happy just to listen."
- "We can keep this simple. Do you want ideas or just space?"
- "I will not push advice unless you want it."
- "It makes sense to take a moment before deciding."
- "Would a small next step feel useful, or not yet?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: "You should just..."

Better: "That sounds hard. Do you want advice or space?"

Best: "That sounds like the kind of day where advice too fast would be annoying. Do you want solutions, solidarity, or a bit of both?"

2. Weak: "Have you tried..."

Better: "What have you already tried?"

Best: "Before I suggest the obvious, what have you already tried and what felt useless?"

3. Weak: "At least..."

Better: "That sounds frustrating."

Best: "I can see why that would get under your skin. It sounds less like workload and more like being taken for granted."

4. Weak: "Here is what I would do."

Better: "Want my read?"

Best: "I have one practical thought, but I do not want to steamroll you. Useful, or not yet?"

DECISION TREE

If They are venting emotionally

Reflect and stay with them. Do not advise yet.

"That sounds exhausting."

If They ask "what should I do?"

Give concise advice, but check the desired outcome first.

"What are you hoping to protect or change?"

If They reject your advice

You probably advised too early or solved the wrong problem. Ask what matters most.

"Fair. What is the part that actually matters here?"

If They keep repeating the issue

Summarise and ask whether they want to problem-solve now.

"You have come back to this a few times. Want to think through a next step?"

If Urgent action is needed

Be direct, but briefly acknowledge the feeling.

"This is stressful. Let's deal with the urgent bit now, then talk properly."

If Advice would be unwelcome

Use validation, curiosity and support instead of fixing.

"I'm just going to be on your side with this one."

SCENARIOS

Friend venting

Reflect the emotion and offer solidarity before any fix. Do not open with obvious solutions. — *"That sounds awful. Do you want solutions or solidarity?"*

Partner upset

Do not fix the feeling. Show you are with them first. — *"I'm here. Tell me the part that is bothering you most."*

Colleague at work

Ask whether they want a sounding board or practical options, and keep advice brief. — *"Do you want a sounding board, or a couple of practical options?"*

Leadership or coaching

Clarify whether they want coaching or a recommendation. Avoid rescuing too quickly. — *"Do you want me to help you think, or do you want my recommendation?"*

Digital or text

Use one clean mode-check sentence rather than a wall of suggestions. — *"Want advice, or just a sympathetic witness?"*

Shy or guarded person

Offer space and control. No pressure to solve it right now. — *"No pressure to solve this now. I'm happy just to listen."*

WHEN NOT TO USE

- Physical safety or an immediate emergency, where you act rather than reflect
- They have clearly and explicitly asked for advice
- Urgent time pressure where a decision is genuinely needed now
- They are stuck in repeated venting with no movement and want to move on
- Practical help is what is needed, not emotional attunement
- You would only be stalling with mode-checks to avoid giving a straight answer

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the reflex

Three times today, catch the urge to jump in with advice, reassurance or a fix. Just notice it and let it pass without acting on it.

Day 2 — Name the hard part

Take three things people said recently and write one sentence each naming the feeling underneath (unfairness, overload, disrespect), not the fix.

Day 3 — Own the mode check

Write and say aloud three natural versions of "Do you want me to listen, think it through, or suggest options?" in your own voice, until none sound scripted.

Day 4 — Reflect, then pause

In one real conversation, reflect the hard part once and then stay silent. Let them fill the space instead of rushing to solve it.

Day 5 — Ask before advising

When you have a suggestion, ask permission first ("I have one thought, if it's useful") and offer only one idea, not a plan.

Day 6 — Check the fit

After giving a suggestion, ask whether it actually fits. If it does not, return to understanding rather than pushing the idea harder.

Day 7 — Recover a miss

Catch one moment where you advised too fast and use a recovery line: "I jumped into fixing too quickly. What do I need to understand first?"

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I hold advice until I understood what they actually wanted?
- Was my wording shorter than my instinct?
- Did I reflect the feeling before offering anything?
- Did the person have more room after my move, or less?
- Did I leave room for them to correct or decline?
- Did I notice whether it actually helped?